DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Which Beliefs Deny God's Unity?

Daat Tevunot §36

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §36 (continued: the mistaken philosophies, errors one to four) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Wednesday 26 October 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are

On Rosh Hodesh, the class continued from the second part of §36, "veomnam ikkar hayediah hazot." The Neshamah had asked why so much emphasis is placed on yihud Hashem: surely it just means one God and not two. The Sekhel answered that it means far more: there is absolutely no power or force with any influence in the world apart from the will of the Almighty. That is why we need to be reminded of it so often.

Now the Ramhal says that the main point of this principle is to separate ourselves from mistaken philosophies. Some took hold of idol worshippers, some of the ignorant masses, some of non-Jews, and some of rebellious Jews. He lists five, and will show how yihud Hashem refutes each. All of them accept that God exists; the question is whether He alone rules.

Error one: God is too high to be involved

God exists, but He is so elevated and holy that He would not involve Himself in our petty world. He created it and left it to be run by the things He appointed: the sun, the moon, the stars, the constellations, the sarim (heavenly ministers).

The Ramhal says idolatry came in two forms, and this is the first: God is too exalted for lowly things, and beneath Him are powers who actually run the world. So people made altars and services for the sun and the stars, slaughtering and burning incense to please each one and draw down what they wanted. A participant asked about people who worship figures of animals. The Rabbi said that if they serve them as conduits of power, that is exactly this category. The cruder believe the figures are gods themselves; the more sophisticated see them as ministers of God.

The Rabbi connected this to Bilaam, who in one of Rashi's interpretations is surprised that God concerns Himself with the most intimate moments of Israel's lives. People find it hard to think that God is there too.

How does this differ from what we learnt in Derech Hashem, that God's flow passes through the stars? The flow does pass through them, which is why we say "mazal tov," a good flow. But the stars have no independent power, and we do not serve them to obtain good. The Rabbi

added that this applies to Jews too: someone who wears red strings and lives by mazal is placing himself under these forces.

Error two: two powers, good and evil

God forbid to say God has left the world; He is involved, but there are two powers, one doing good and one doing evil. Everything in nature has its opposite, so, they argue, an all-good God must be matched by an all-bad one, which is why the world has both.

The Gemara records a heretic telling Amemar that the upper half of a person belongs to one god and the lower half to another. The Rabbi identified this with Zoroastrianism, the dualism of that time. Its believers prayed to the good god in the morning and the dark god in the evening, so that the night would not be so dark or cold. That, he said, is why our morning and evening blessings stress that the same God brings the light and brings the night.

This philosophy tries to answer the age-old question: if there is one all-powerful God and He is all good, why is there evil? Yihud Hashem rejects their answer. There is only one God, and somehow both good and bad come from Him. How, will be discussed.

Error three: God created nature and left it

This, says the Ramhal, is the view of most people, and the Rabbi said it is still true today. No ministers and no second god, but God created nature and now the world runs by itself. The Rabbi divided it in two: - **3a, it is all me:** you make your own luck; work harder and you earn more; your sharpness is everything, and anything bad is because I did not work hard enough. As Ekev warns, "you will say, my strength and the might of my hand made me this wealth." - **3b, it is all nature or luck:** things just run by an inherent nature, or "karma," with nothing to do with God.

Both deny yihud Hashem: either you are the power, or blind luck is.

Pantheism and Hakham David Nieto

A participant asked about seeing God in nature. The Rabbi distinguished two ideas: - **Pantheism**, Spinoza's view, that God is nature and nature is God, so that there is really nothing beyond nature. That is heresy. - **Panentheism**, that God is within everything and holds everything in being. That is acceptable. He said Chabad takes yihud Hashem so far that everything we see is only an illusion and everything has a divine spark.

He told the story of Hakham David Nieto, rabbi of the Spanish and Portuguese community, who in 1704, during the Spinoza controversy, gave a sermon at Bevis Marks urging people to see God through nature. The community's board, anxious about any Spinozist leanings, accused him of being a secret pantheist. The case was taken to Hakham Sevi, who ruled that Nieto was saying the truth: not that God is nature, but that within nature you see God. Nieto, also a doctor, wrote Matteh Dan, called the second Kuzari, and is buried in the East End near Queen Mary University.

Asked whether the claim that the nations are under mazal is itself the third error, the Rabbi said that even a non-Jew who places himself under Hashem's hashgahah is no longer under mazal, and a Jew who places himself under mazal will be under mazal.

Error four: God rejected Israel

This is the view of some non-Jews. There is one God, He is in control and involved in the world. He originally chose the Jewish people, but they sinned so badly that they prevented Him from doing them good, as the verse says, "Sur yeladekha teshi," you weakened the Rock who bore you. So He forsook them and replaced them with another nation. The proof, they say, is the length of the exile and how the Jews have been scattered across the world. The Rabbi identified this as the Christian view.

The fifth philosophy, and how yihud Hashem wipes them all out, was left for the next class. From the following week Minhah and Arvit would be at 4.15, with Derech Hashem after it through the winter.

Summary

- The main purpose of knowing yihud Hashem is to reject philosophies that accept God but deny that He alone rules.
- Error one: God is too exalted, and ministers such as the stars run the world; the flow passes through them, but they have no power of their own.
- Error two: dualism, a good god and an evil god, which tries to explain the existence of evil.
- Error three: God made nature and left it, whether to my efforts or to blind luck; true pantheism is heresy, while seeing God within nature is correct.
- Error four: God rejected Israel for its sins and replaced it with another nation.

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